
Faster, Higher, Further Apart

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Abstract

In light of recent failures by the German Athletics Association (DLV) at the international level, this report examines the structural development of the extended national elite. Using a dataset of over 226,000 entries from the German rankings from 2001 to 2025, we analyze the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic and long-term trends in performance spreads. We utilize World Athletics Scores to make performances comparable across disciplines. Our results show a significant decline in performance during the pandemic (-2.57% median) and an increasing polarization of the national elite. While the absolute top performers improved, the extended elite declined. This decrease in performance density is particularly evident among men and in technical disciplines and suggests structural deficiencies in coaching presence and internal competition.

1. Introduction

As the world's largest athletics association, the Deutscher Leichtathletik-Verband (DLV) is tasked with facilitating peak individual performance and maintaining an internationally competitive national team ([Deutscher Leichtathletik-Verband, n.d.](#)). However, zero medals at the 2023 World Athletics Championships in Budapest and a historic low medal count at the 2024 Paris Olympics have left the organization in a sobering position. Although individual athletes still occasionally reach the podium, the declining return on investment in terms of Olympic success (?) raises questions about the underlying health of the national talent pool.

While medals are the most visible metric of success, they reflect only the peak of elite performance and offer little insight into how performance is distributed within the elite level. To examine potential structural shifts [or longitudinal

developments], we analyze the top 35 rankings from 2001 to 2025 based on two research questions. First, we exploratively assess the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic as a short-term disruption to the performance development. Second, motivated by observed performance drop-offs beyond the top positions, we assess whether the performance gap within the elite has widened over time. Such a trend may reflect reduced internal competitive intensity, which can weaken international success, as elite development relies on strong competitive environments at the club level (Tihanyi, 2001, cited in ?).

Our analytical approach is detailed in Section 2, where we describe the data processing and justify the analytical framework. Building on this, we will analyze performance metrics to identify structural trends and evaluate our research questions (Section 3). Finally, Section 4 discusses the implications of these findings.

2. Data and Methods

The data were retrieved from the official archive by the Deutscher Leichtathletik-Verband (DLV), which documents the top performances across the major athletic disciplines (including running events, hurdles and steeplechase, jumping events, throwing events, and combined events) from 2001 to 2025. The archive covers performances across gender (male, female) and age groups (under 14 up to open class).

As the data for each year, age group, and gender are stored in separate PDF files, we used *pdfplumber* in combination with specific regular expressions to handle formatting differences over years. Outliers due to entry inconsistencies in the original files (e.g., irregular time formats) were corrected when the intended values could be inferred from external sources. Minor data gaps resulting from parsing errors were manually completed by referencing the original PDF files. Non-recurrent distances (e.g., [3000 m steeplechase and] 7.5 km events in selected youth categories) were excluded, yielding a final dataset of 226,683 entries.

We standardized discipline names, birth years and converted performance marks into numeric values (seconds for track events and meters for field events) to allow sta-

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Project report for the “Data Literacy” course at the University of Tübingen, Winter 2025/26 (Module ML4201). Style template based on the [ICML style files 2025](#). Copyright 2025 by the author(s).

tistical analyses. To facilitate comparisons across events, performances were transformed using World Athletics scoring tables, which express results on a common point scale. To facilitate comparisons across events (e.g., 100m sprint vs. javelin throw), performances were transformed using World Athletics scoring tables (IAAF scores) (Wor). The IAAF scores are a standardization metric maps performance marks onto a common point scale. They are released annually by World Athletics as tables in PDF files, but unfortunately there is no public formula to calculate the scores directly from performance marks. However, some people have tried to reverse engineer the formulas for the scoring tables. The one that we use, originates from a blog post by Jeff Chen (Chen, 2019). He parsed the PDF files of the scoring tables and fitted a quadratic function to the data points to get an approximate formula with coefficients for each discipline. We implemented his formulas in our data processing pipeline to convert all performance marks into World Athletics points for comparability across disciplines. In the following, all our calculations and analyses are based on these IAAF scores.

To ensure a robust and representative sample for all statistical evaluations, the dataset included the top 35 national performances in each group and year. This threshold ensures that there is enough data for all groups. A "Group" is defined as the combination of Gender x Age group x Discipline, maintaining consistency with the original leaderboards. The study focuses on the U18, U20, and Adult age groups, as these represent the most relevant categories, since these age groups compete at international world level championships. To allow for cross-disciplinary comparison, four discipline groups were defined based on current team selection criteria (DLV): sprints, runs, throws, and jumps.

Throughout this study, comparisons between time periods are reported as the relative percentage change. This value represents the percentage difference between the end and start periods, normalized to the start period. For performance levels, a positive value indicates improvement. For performance spread, a positive value indicates a widening gap. General performance shifts are assessed based on the relative change between the medians. These are selected for their robustness against outliers and the non-normal distribution of the data. Statistical significance is determined using the Mann-Whitney U test. To quantify the performance distribution, we analyze the relative change of a specific measure of performance variance. Significance is determined using bootstrap resampling ($B = 10,000$), which is optimal for our small sample size ($N = 12$). We calculated 95% confidence intervals (CIs) for the differences in performance variance. An CI containing zero indicates no significant change in performance density.

To investigate the impact of the pandemic on professional

athletics, an exploratory data analysis was performed to identify structural and qualitative shifts in performance. To gain an initial understanding of the dataset, a heatmap-based plot was employed. This visualization maps the aggregate frequency of competitive entries across a grid of months and years, offering a clear view of seasonal activity levels and data density.

To isolate the specific impact of the pandemic year, the dataset was partitioned into two distinct cohorts. The baseline group consists of all pooled IAAF scores recorded between 2015 and 2019 and the other group consists of all IAAF scores recorded in 2020. This aggregation serves as a stable reference for "normal" pre-pandemic performance levels. This analysis was performed to investigate a potential general trend across the investigated groups. To evaluate the directionality and magnitude of the performance shift, the relative percentage difference of the median was calculated between the two time periods. Through this approach, the exact degree of performance deviation relative to the pre-pandemic baseline was precisely quantified.

To evaluate the impact of the pandemic on general performance density, we analyzed the dispersion of IAAF scores. This allows us to determine whether the competitive field became more spread out or remained stable during the 2020 season. The interquartile range (IQR) was chosen as the main measure of dispersion instead of the standard deviation (STD) because it is more robust when analyzing elite athletic data. High-performance scores often include "outliers," extraordinary performances that can greatly distort the standard deviation. The primary metric for measuring the performance spread is the relative percentage change of IQR in 2020 compared to the pooled baseline from 2015 to 2019. To analyze long-term structural changes, we compare the five-year periods 2001–2005 and 2021–2025. This timeframe smooths out annual fluctuations and, through a broader data base, ensures the statistical validity of the results. The analysis is conducted on two levels: 1. Recording performance trends and density for all groups to identify group differences. 2. Examining the development to identify the structure in which performance changes occur. This allows us to identify general trends and determine the structure of the changes.

To measure the performance density, we define the performance gap (G_p) between the three best and the three worst (e.g., 33rd–35th place) in our data set for the two time periods. The averaging of the top 3 reflects the international standard of success (podium), while the bottom 3 provide a stable and comparable baseline. We used the performance gap to measure the breadth of performance at the top level and utilized all available information (e.g., rankings) from our dataset to measure polarization. Mathematically, the gap (G_p) is defined as follows:

$$G_p = \left(\frac{1}{3|P|} \sum_{y \in P} \sum_{r=1}^3 x_{y,r} \right) - \left(\frac{1}{3|P|} \sum_{y \in P} \sum_{r=33}^{35} x_{y,r} \right) \quad (1)$$

where $x_{y,r}$ represents the individual performance of rank r in year y , and $|P|$, in our case $|P| = 5$, represents the number of years per period. The development of the performance gap was calculated as the relative percentage change between the two five-year periods.

To analyze the development of the different rankings, we calculate the arithmetic mean for each rank across all groups for the start and end periods. For each rank, even when differentiating by age group and gender, the sample size is at least $n = 80$. According to the central limit theorem, we can assume a normal distribution and thus calculate the arithmetic mean. The development of each rank was determined by calculating the percentage change between the start and end periods, normalized to the start period. A positive value indicates an improvement in the average ranking, a negative value a decline.

During the period under review, several rule changes were implemented regarding hurdle heights and throwing weights, particularly in the U18 (2012) and U20 age groups (2001) (Pro). Therefore, the affected disciplines were excluded from median and rank analyses, as changes in these parameters are directly attributable to equipment changes and not to athletic development. However, the performance gap analysis was retained, as this variance can be calculated independently of the absolute values.

3. Results

Analysis of the distribution of seasonal events reveals a significant temporal shift in the competition calendar. In 2020, events were concentrated in the latter part of the year, which marked a clear departure from the traditional mid-summer peak. This shift toward late summer and autumn remains partially visible in 2021, though the schedule shows a gradual return to the pre-pandemic seasonal norm.

The Mann-Whitney-U test confirms a significant decline in performance levels across all athletic categories during the 2020 season compared to the 2015–2019 baseline ($p < 0.05$). The overall median IAAF score decreased by 2.57%, falling from 914.0 to 890.5 points. The most substantial impact was observed in the Throw category, which saw a 3.99% reduction in median performance. Jumps and Sprints followed with declines of 2.58% and 1.35%, respectively. In contrast, the Run category demonstrated the highest resilience, showing the smallest significant decrease of 0.88%.

The bootstrap analysis of the Interquartile Range (IQR) reveals significant shifts in performance dispersion during the 2020 season compared to the 2015–2019 baseline. The most pronounced effect was observed in the Sprint category, where dispersion rose by 12.93% (95% CI: [3.42%, 20.00%]), followed by the Run category with a significant increase of 6.41% (95% CI: [0.65%, 13.82%]). In contrast, both the Throw category (−0.18%; 95% CI: [−6.99%, 9.42%]) and the Jump category (−6.79%; 95% CI: [−11.85%, 4.58%]) showed no statistically significant changes in dispersion.

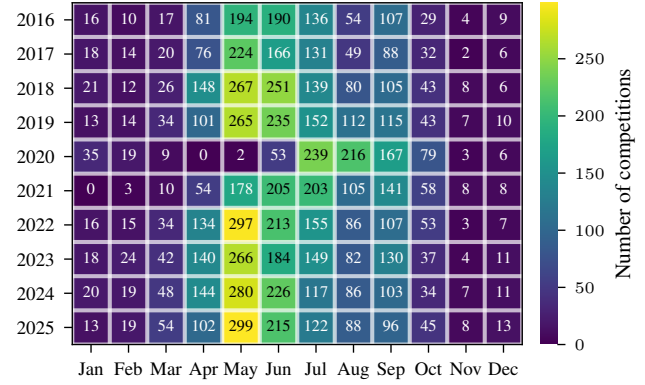


Figure 1.

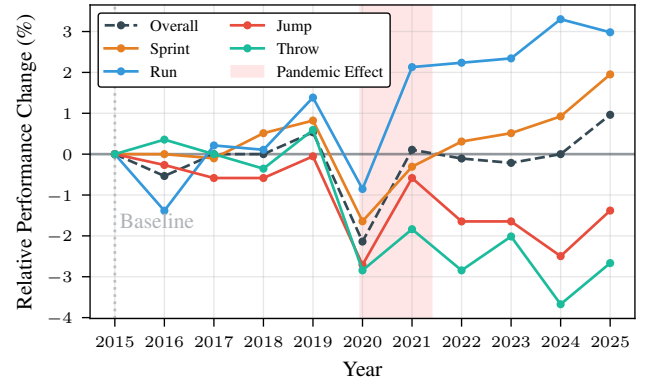


Figure 2.

Figure 3 shows the change in performance spread and typical performance development from 2021–2025 compared to 2001–2005 in many groups. The analysis of the performance data encompasses 106 groups, where X groups were excluded for median calculations (see Section 2). Overall, a decrease in performance density is evident. The best performers are improving, while the weaker performers are declining. While median performance trends were nearly balanced with 38 groups significantly improving and 37 declining, the performance spread shows a strong asymmetry:

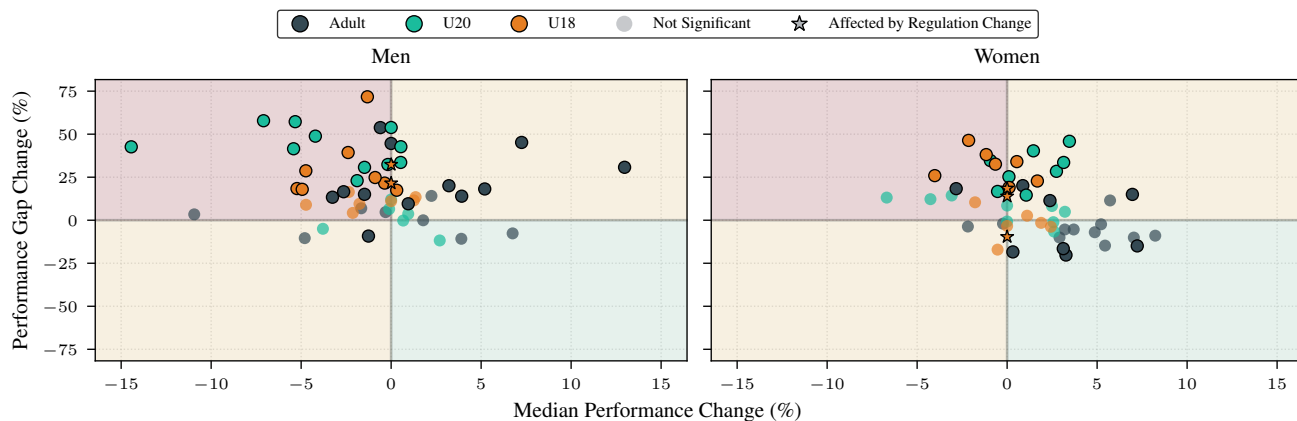


Figure 3. Relationship between median performance and change in performance gap (2001–2005 to 2021–2025). The scatter plot shows the percentage change in median performance (x-axis) and the change in performance gap (y-axis) for male (left) and female (right) groups, categorized by age group. The transparency of the markers indicates the statistical significance of the change in performance gap (via bootstrap method). Disciplines affected by regulatory changes are centered at 0 for the median, as only performance gap remains comparable across the time periods.

A significant expansion was observed in 49.1% (52 groups), while a reduction was only seen in 4.7% (6 groups). This widening of the performance gap was most pronounced among men, especially in the U20 (70.6%) age group. In contrast, the women's groups showed significantly greater median progress: 63.3% improved compared to only 36.5% of the men's groups. Furthermore, discipline-specific trends emerged: The running and sprinting disciplines showed the most significant progress, with an improvement-to-decline ratio of 3:1 and 2:1 respectively. In contrast, the technical disciplines showed a significant decline: the declines outweighed the improvements by a ratio of 6:1 in throwing and 2.6:1 in jumping.

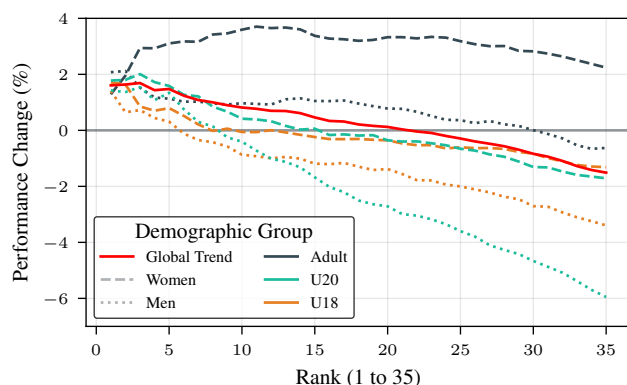


Figure 4. Performance development across ranks 1–35 (2001–05 to 2021–25). Shown is the percentage change in the average performance values of all groups overall, as well as broken down by age group and gender.

Figure 4 illustrates a linear polarization of performance. While the top-ranked company improved by an average of 1.61%, the 35th-rank declined by 1.51%, with the turning point towards negative growth being reached at the 22nd-rank. This polarization is not apparent only among adult women; all ranks from third place onward improved more than the top two ranks. Overall, women in all age groups perform better than their male counterparts. The most significant declines were seen in the male age groups under 18 and under 20. In the under-18 age group, the decline begins as early as rank 6, while in the under-20 age group it starts as early as rank 9.

4. Discussion & Conclusion

Generally for all Discussion:

- Weniger mitglieder -> weniger trainer -> insbesondere technische disziplinen - Corona -> weniger/schlechtere trainingsbedingungen für technische disziplinen, im gegen- teil dazu: laufen hatte aufschwung erlebt - Frauen sind noch nicht am Ende der entwicklung

Our results confirm a systematic increase in the performance gap, which aligns with the observed decline in performance at national championships. This reduction in performance density is particularly evident among men and young athletes, where performance differences have widened significantly. A major reason for this structural change is likely the 11.9% decrease in German Athletics Association (DLV) membership, exacerbated by a 26.6% drop in the 27- to 60-year-old age group (Lei). Since this age group contains a large number of coaches, its decline directly impacts tech-

nical disciplines that rely heavily on expert, individualized training. In contrast, women's athletics shows more improvements, which is probably due to a "catch-up effect" as a result of historically delayed professionalization.

Ultimately, the data reveals a polarization of performance: while professionalization protects the national elite, the second tier is shrinking. This confirms our hypothesis that the lack of internal pressure—true to the principle that "competition promotes performance"—has isolated the German elite and ill-prepared them for the intensity of international competition. The zero medal results of recent years are therefore not anomalies, but the predictable outcome of a shrinking talent pool.

Corona had an influence, also differently on the discipline groups, changed the structure maybe with less interest in technical disciplines... In running competitions, the overall improvement in average performance was significantly influenced by the introduction of carbon fiber shoes in 2016 (Willwacher et al., 2023). Furthermore, the COVID-19 pandemic led to uneven development. Endurance athletes may benefited from focused, uninterrupted training blocks (Venkatesan, 2022). In contrast, athletes in technical disciplines were hindered by the closure of training facilities.

One limitation is the focus on the top 35. We cannot make any statements about the general development in all of amateur sports. The analysis only considers advanced competitive sports. Whether the observed trend continues linearly would need to be investigated with further analyses. Comparison to other countries?!

The increase in the performance spread indicates a structural change in organized athletics. A future focus should be placed on strengthening the grassroots level and coaches in popular sport. Following the principle of "the grassroots supporting the elite," this will allow for more top performances and could bring German athletics closer to the world's elite.

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